



OPEN Ideology and free speech values predict content moderation preferences: cross-national evidence across targets of hate speech

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With over 4 billion people using social media platforms daily, decisions about what content to allow or moderate have profound implications for global public discourse, democratic deliberation, and users' psychological well-being. This study examines cross-national variation in content moderation preferences by exposing participants in 10 countries to a standardized example of hate speech: a hateful post modeled on text that X (formerly Twitter) had cited in its content moderation guidelines. Across contexts, exposure to such content triggers widespread support for intervention, with minimal differences based on the experimentally varied identity of the target. However, significant variation emerges across countries. The United States stands out for its comparatively lower support for moderation of hate speech, while countries like France, Brazil, and South Africa exhibit much stronger demand. Within most countries, political ideology predicts support: individuals on the right are less likely to endorse removal or suspension than those on the left. Crucially, values around freedom of speech versus harm prevention consistently shape preferences across all contexts. Those who prioritize prevention from harm are markedly more likely to support hard forms of moderation (e.g., account suspension and content take-downs). These findings highlight that moderation preferences are shaped less by the specific target than by individuals' deeper commitments regarding free expression and harm prevention.

Keywords Social media, Content moderation, Freedom of speech

Social media platforms have long been celebrated as powerful tools for personal and political expression. More recently, however, they have increasingly been criticized for their role in amplifying misinformation and hate speech^{1,2}. As these platforms continue to grow³, the challenge of balancing free expression with the need to protect users from harm has become more urgent^{4,5}. The debate over content moderation—what to allow, what to remove, and who decides—has sparked polarized discussions worldwide^{6–10}. In the United States (US), the debate has become so contentious that the Trump administration used economic pressure to defend American free speech norms abroad, warning the UK during trade talks that its hate speech laws could harm US platform profits and weaken the UK's negotiating position, and threatening Brazil with a 50% tariff over court-ordered content removals targeting US social media companies^{11,12}.

The global stakes of platform governance and the influence of users as moderators

While digital technology companies, civil society organizations, and policymakers engage in these debates, the perspectives of users are largely overlooked. Yet, users have always played an integral role in content moderation. Early efforts, such as Facebook's content flagging system, relied heavily on user reports to identify harmful material, reflecting an early crowdsourced approach to moderation¹³. Similarly, Twitter's Birdwatch program, which was launched in 2021 and was later rebranded as Community Notes under X, further brought user participation into content moderation. The expanded role of community notes along with Meta's removal of third-party fact-checking partnerships¹⁴, have renewed emphasis on user-centered moderation as a prominent

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